How NOT to Relax

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at https://archiveofourown.org/works/82039371.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Modern AU, Canon Species, Magicat Catra (She-Ra), Fishing, beach, Catra is in Love with Adora (She-Ra), Protective Catra (She-Ra), Adora is horrible at relaxing, Catra is sick of Adora's Shit, POV Catra (She-Ra), Mild Language, Domestic

Language:
English

Series:
Part 7 of SPOP Discord Prompts

Collections:
SPOP Creative Flex

Stats:
Published: 2026-03-29 Words: 4,120 Chapters: 1/1

How NOT to Relax

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at https://archiveofourown.org/works/82039371.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Modern AU, Canon Species, Magicat Catra (She-Ra), Fishing, beach, Catra is in Love with Adora (She-Ra), Protective Catra (She-Ra), Adora is horrible at relaxing, Catra is sick of Adora's Shit, POV Catra (She-Ra), Mild Language, Domestic

Language:
English

Series:
Part 7 of SPOP Discord Prompts

Collections:
SPOP Creative Flex

Stats:
Published: 2026-03-29 Words: 4,120 Chapters: 1/1

How NOT to Relax

by AuthorWithoutaName

Summary

Adora needs to relax. It's not *just* Catra that knows that. It's not just their friends that have noticed. A doctor has. An actual, medical professional, has just straight up told Adora that she needs to relax. She needs to stop pushing herself. She needs to rest. In Catra's mind, that would mean that Adora should prop her feet up, and maybe cuddle with her on the couch. They could watch some movies, order some takeout... The general relaxing ~~shit~~ stuff people do.

Adora decides that a doctor telling her relax means that she must try fishing... Because fishing is a relaxing hobby, right?! For anyone else, it might be, but for Adora, it most certainly isn't...

(Based on the Creative Flex server weekly prompt: Going fishing)

Notes

It feels like it's been a bit! I worked on this piece throughout the week last week. I'm trying to get back into the swing of things writing-wise. Hoping I can work through my Google Docs backlog and finish up some of my AO3 WIPs this year. Anyway, hope ya'll enjoy this little fic!

See the end of the work for more notes

Fish. Salt. The scents lingered in the air, their heaviness causing Catra's nose to twitch. Her ears flickered. Waves crashed onto the shoreline and in the distance. Seagulls squawked overhead. The sun was out. It was warm, not unbearably hot, but still noticeable. Spring was ending. Summer was on the horizon. Soon the beach would be filled with families. Soon it would be loud and overwhelming. Not yet though, and for that, Catra was grateful.

Clouds, white and fluffy, filled the sky. They moved slowly and steadily. Every now and then, they would block out the sun for a few meager moments, allowing Catra to feel some relief from it.

It was a nice day. Calm. Relaxing.

"Augh!!!"

At least it was *supposed* to be…

"Isn't the whole point of this for you to take it slow and relax?" Catra asked, deadpanned. Today was a bad idea. She knew that it was a bad idea. No matter how many times she tried to tell Adora that, the blonde idiot just wouldn't listen!

Spending the day out on a beach wasn't Catra's first choice. It wouldn't have been her second choice. It wouldn't have even been her third, or fourth, or even *fifth* choice. The beach had sand. It had water. The two things she absolutely **hated**. She wasn't about to let Adora go by herself though. She especially wouldn't let Adora go by herself when she knew without a doubt that it would be a horrible, horrible day. Someone had to save the blonde idiot from herself. Apparently, Catra was that someone, not that she would complain.

Adora huffed in the distance. Annoyed. Irritated. *Pissed*. Catra could *hear* it in that one, little exhale of Adora's. Her tail thumped against the towel she was laying on. It drummed against the coarse, colorful fabric underneath her.

Six. They had brought *six* beach towels with them. One was completely spread out with Catra lying on it. Her arms were folded behind her head, like a makeshift pillow. She probably could have used Adora's sole towel as a pillow. Adora probably would have obliged. There was no doubt that Adora would have rolled the towel up into a makeshift pillow for her, if she had asked. Adora *had* rolled up four of the towels and had carefully constructed them as a wall around Catra's towel, shielding and protecting her from the sand she detested so much.

Sand sucked. She hated it. It got deep into her fur. It felt itchy on her skin. It was nearly impossible to wash out. Adora had made the little fort for her. Adora had even carried straight from the car to the fort immediately after she had built it for her. Not only had Adora carried her (she had actually *yonked* Catra out of the car and brought her to the protected spot without even being asked), she had carried Catra *bridal style* of all things!

Catra wanted to hate it. Adora had *just* gotten a lecture earlier this week about how she needed to relax and rest. She had gotten that lecture from a doctor of all people! Catra (not to mention all of her and Adora's friends) had hoped that Adora would take the lecture seriously. To Adora's credit, she was *trying*. Apparently, she just couldn't relax indoors (a true pity…).

She had looked up at Adora, but any reprimands died on her lips. Adora was smiling as she carried her. Her bright, sweet smile. Her blue-gray eyes shining. Catra then settled into Adora's arms, grateful and enjoying the warmth of the blonde's arms. Snuggling in and relishing their closeness in the moment.

Unfortunately, the moment didn't last. After carefully putting her in the protected fort, Adora had gone back to the car for the fishing equipment. Equipment she had *just* bought today. Catra wanted to curse that stupid fishing equipment.

One: it took *her* Adora away from her. Adora *should* have been snuggling with her.

Two: No one (as far as Catra knew) mastered and found fishing relaxing during their first time. No one!! Even Bow had seemed frustrated when he had tried fishing awhile back (at least, according to Glimmer).

There was a sharp whip. The whirl of a wheel or a gear as it spun. Another frustrated exhale. Yeah… Adora was pissed. Well, Catra was a little pissed off right now. The two of them could have been home right now. They *should* be home right now. Instead they were outside, sweating (and in Adora's case probably burning) under the sun.

"This is stupid," Adora grumbled.

Catra didn't even bother to sit up. Based off of Adora's tone, she imagined the blonde's furrowed brow. She could picture the blonde's blue-gray eyes burning with both determination and irritation. She knew Adora. She had known Adora since she had first formed memories. Actually, her first memory was of the day the two of them had met. Despite her frustration, Adora wouldn't want to give up. She would be determined to catch something; anything, really. As long as it had fins and scales, she would be happy. Whenever Adora set her mind on something, she would follow it through, even to the detriment of her own health…

Catra sighed, a thought occurring to her. Reluctantly, she sat up. With a single finger, she lifted her sunglasses just over her mismatched eyes. She wished she hadn't, then she could have just been laying on the beach in ignorance still. But she had and now she would have something else to add on her list of Adora worries.

Adora's arms, legs, and the back of her neck were all bright, bright red. Catra allowed the sunglasses to face back over her eyes. Adora always seemed to sunburn easily. She needed to reapply sunscreen every hour or so to stay ahead of it. Catra inhaled, breathing in the scents of the coast. The smell of sunscreen didn't seem to linger in the air anymore. She knew Adora had put some on before. She vividly remembered Adora

putting sunscreen on just after they had arrived at the beach. How long had they been out here?

"We could just go home," Catra offered. She kept her voice as neutral as she could.

Going home would be nice. Going home would be *amazing*, actually! They could order some food. They could watch a movie (maybe snuggle on the couch…). They could enjoy each other's company and the comforts of the great (incredible really) indoors!

Melog would enjoy it if they went back home. The kitten was a new addition in little life and Catra hated leaving them home alone for too long. At work, she would usually use her breaks to watch the pet-camera Adora had set up. She thought about glancing at her phone and see if she had enough of a signal to watch the pet-cam for a few minutes.

Damn, she missed Melog right now.

"I'm not going until I catch something," Adora muttered. Her voice was low, frustrated.

Catra huffed, irritated with the blonde. Catching a fish was never a guarantee.

"You can go home if you want."

"Well, we took the same car, so I'm stuck here as long as you're here," Catra sighed.

Despite her best efforts, she could hear the frustration in her own voice. She felt a twinge of guilt about that. She didn't *want* Adora to know she was getting fed up with being out here so long. Adora would feel guilty and then that would cause a mental spiral that could affect both of them for days.

"You can take the car. I'll get a Lyft or something," Adora replied. There was an edge to her voice, one that Catra didn't like. She knew it wasn't directed at her. Adora was just disgruntled about

the lack of fish. Still, Catra had to remind herself of that. She couldn't help but feel some anger at Adora's tone. She fought the urge to be defensive and snap.

Maybe checking the pet-cam would calm her. If she made sure Melog was doing okay, that would ease one of her stresses. Without looking, she snatched her phone up from next to her. She clicked the *on* button and was immediately greeted with a notification: *Alert: Adora, battery at 10%. Remind Adora to recharge now. Certain features are now offline.*

"Adora…" she growled under her breath. Why hadn't she charged her phone?!

"Your phone is at like ten percent. You're not gonna be able to get a Lyft," Catra said simply. She had no idea how long Adora would stay out if she went home without her. At ten percent, Adora's phone might die before she's ready to call it quits and then how would she get home?

"Fine. I'll get you a Lyft, and I'll take the car," Adora replied, her ever budding frustration teeming in her voice.

Catra bit back a snarky reply. Again, she didn't like the idea of leaving Adora with her phone on the brink of death. What if something happened? What if she got hurt or something? If her phone died, she wouldn't be able to reach out.

"Adora," Catra began slowly. Keeping her voice calm was harder than she thought it would be. This whole day had been about trying to reduce Adora's stress though. If she got mad, then Adora's stress would get worse and then– She shook the thought out of her head.

"Your phone's going to die before you decide to quit," she continued, in a matter-of-fact tone, "I'm not leaving you." She settled on that response. It was simple and to the point. That last part may have also been a promise. A promise that had followed the two of them since their childhood.

"Catra, I can…" Adora's words faltered and then stopped. She opened her mouth again but no words came out and she shut it. Catra could see the gears turning in Adora's head. She was sure the blonde was going through possible counter-arguments to her concerns. Any reply she thought of died before it could reach her lips and she stayed silent.

Despite the sound of seagulls and waves, Catra could hear Adora take a deep breath. Her ears flickered in response. Knowing Adora, she was probably gearing herself up to finally say something.

"...Fine…" Adora sighed, and she turned back towards the sea, her attention on her white fishing pole once again.

Catra watched her for a bit before settling back down and laying on her back again. She switched over to the pet-cam app. Cat toys were scattered about the living-room. Catra's eyes flickered all over the screen. Her heart started to beat a little more quickly as she searched for Melog. Where could they be? Every moment she didn't see them, dread grew inside her. Just when she was about to call Adora over, she saw them. A little black ball of fluff, curled up in a small ball on the couch.

A small smile flashed across Catra's face. Good. They were doing okay. She turned her phone off, intending to put it back down. Before she could, she felt it vibrate. It didn't bother to sit up again, opting instead to hold it just inches from her face, hoping against hope that she didn't accidentally drop it and smack herself in the face. What an embarrassment that would be.

She clicked the on button. The screen glowed to life. A text from Scorpia greeted her.

How's it going, Wildcat?

Catra immediately began typing out a reply. Her fingers danced across the screen in what Adora called *sonic-level* speed.

About how we expected…

Text bubbles and then:

That bad, huh?

…

Words failed Catra at that moment; or rather, *acceptable*, non-mean words failed her. There was a lot she *wanted* to say. Adora can't relax to save her life (which might actually become the issue later on. She shuttered at *that* thought.). Adora's too stubborn for her own good (again, true! But bitching to Scorpia about that wouldn't help anyone and if Adora ever found out about her telling Scorpia *that*, well… then Adora would be pissed and then she would feel guilty, and that meant Catra would feel guilty, and if she could just avoid that, then she would.).

Catra took a deep breath.

…Inhale…

…Exhale…

…Inhale…

…Exhale…

She did that for a few more moments. Perfuma would be proud! She had spent… Damn, had she really known Perfuma for years now? Had Perfuma really been patient with her for years now as well? Shit. Maybe she should thank Perfuma one of these days?

Catra regained her composure. She felt (slightly) more relaxed. She began typing again:

It's Adora…

That was all she needed to say. Scorpia knew how Adora was. Adora couldn't relax. Adora wouldn't relax. It wasn't in her nature… though… A part of Catra wondered how much of that was nature and how much of it was nurture. Ms. Hope wasn't

abusive the same way Ms. Weaver was but Catra couldn't deny the fact that Ms. Hope was an abusive piece of shit.

Catra's tail thumped against the towel she laid on. She felt her blood boil as she thought back to her and Adora's childhoods. Neighbors. Childhood friends. More than once, their friendship was threatened by their respective guardians. Ms. Hope was always worried that Catra would be a *distraction* for Adora. Ms. Hope always talked like Adora had some *grand destiny*…

Growing up, Adora couldn't fail. She couldn't stop. She couldn't rest. She studied late into the night, she was into sports (multiple… softball, basketball, soccer…She was in some kind of martial arts, Catra couldn't remember which one though…). More than once, Catra would climb over the fence that separated their backyards. Sometimes she would just talk to Adora as she trained. Other times she would snatch Adora by her hand and convince her to leave for a bit. Rest. There were some woods near their neighborhood. They were a great place to go to hide. To escape. Even if it was just for a few, meager, precious minutes.

Damn.

No wonder Adora was so stressed. She hadn't been allowed to relax ever. She didn't even know how.

Catra's phone dinged. Another message. She felt a wave of gratitude for Scorpia right then, breaking her out of her spiraling thoughts. Anything she thought about her and Adora's childhoods, she would feel anger. A frustration that even with a couple of years of therapy, still hadn't completely left her.

She read the text:

I'm sorry, Wildcat. Anything me or Perfuma can do to help?

A good question. Was there anything anyone could do? Short of just wrapping the blonde idiot up in a blanket, parking her ass on the couch, and forcing her to rest, that is? Scorpia could definitely

do that. She was taller than Adora. Hell, she was probably stronger than Adora. She could lift Adora for her.

Catra could picture it. Adora, wrapped like a burrito in one of the many blankets they had around their shared apartment. The TV was with a movie playing, probably a comedy, those seem to help Adora relax. Scorpia could do it, pluck Adora away from the shore, where she was still fishing (and getting terribly burned… Did she forget to put on sunscreen?!). Scorpia could wrap her up in the blanket. Maybe Perfuma could give one of her patented speeches about mental and physical health, those speeches didn't always work, but every now and then, they did.

Catra began to type out a reply:

I don't think so, but thank you

Scorpia sent back a thumbs up emoji. Catra clicked her phone off and lowered her arms, crossing them on her chest, her phone still beneath her hands. Her ears flickered as she heard another grumble from Adora.

Catra sighed. *Fuck it*.

She rolled onto her knees and slowly stood up. The waves were splashing Adora's feet and her legs, just under her kneecaps. Her fishing line looked as if it were miles away from the shoreline, though Catra knew with certainty that the line wasn't that long. She tore her gaze away from Adora, glancing at the sand outside of her protected towel fort. Her tail thrashed behind her. She didn't want to do this. It would take days to wash the stupid grains of sand out of her fur. She looked up at Adora. Her usually pale skin was red. Bright. Burning. It hurt Catra to look at it.

Fuck. That would definitely hurt for a few days, maybe a couple of weeks…

She glanced down at her phone again and quickly typed out a new message for Scorpia.

Actually, can you grab some aloe vera gel and drop it off later?

Text bubbles. Then:

Sure thing, Wildcat!

A thumbs up accompanied the message.

She felt a wave of gratitude for Scorpia. Her gaze returned to Adora then. She took a deep breath, readying herself. She didn't want to do this. Adora needed her though. Catra stepped over the towel wall, cringing as the sand shifted, crawling into her fur and between her toes. She hissed quietly. It burned. Of course it burned. She should've brought shoes, for a moment, she cursed herself that she didn't.

She jumped backwards, back into the safety of the towel fort. Her feet immediately felt relief from the scolding sand. Out of the corner of her eye, she saw the red of Adora's boots. Her tail thrashed twice.

If she wasn't worried about ruining Adora's boots in the salt water, she would have put those on. It wouldn't have been the first time she had borrowed them. Sure, they were oversized for her feet, but in the dead of winter, when the ground was too cold for her feet, they worked for simple and quick tasks such as checking the mail.

She glanced at Adora. The blonde's back was to her. She was still focused (overly, in Catra's opinion) on fishing.

Alright. She had to psych herself up. *You can do this, Catra.*

She took a slow, hesitant step outside of the towel fort. She bit back a hiss. Did sand always have to be so damn hot? Scalding? With one foot on the towel, and one on the sand, she leapt forward, and sprinted towards the shoreline where Adora was. She swallowed a few curses. The burning. The general itchiness of the sand. She hated it. Adora was lucky that she loved her more than she hated the beach.

She splashed through the coastline. Immediate relief. The water was cold. It was icy, it was nice. It was almost nice enough to make her forget how much she hated the feel of water on her fur.

Almost.

Adora's head perked up. She glanced over her shoulder, her eyes growing wide as they met Catra's.

"Catra, what are you–?"

Catra's tail lashed. An idea. Her ears flickered down, in a way similar to Melog whenever they were about to– Catra leapt forward. As if in anticipation, Adora dropped the fishing rod. She tried to spin around but–

Catra crashed into her, knocking them both into the water.

"Catra, what the–?"

Catra shoved her hand onto Adora's mouth, silencing her.

"Shit, Adora, language," she chided with a smug smile.

The blonde glared at her, her brow furrowing as if to emphasize her annoyance. Catra's tail flickered playfully. If Adora wanted to, she could easily throw Catra off of her. Catra figured that the only reason she wasn't though was because Adora knew how much Catra hated water. It wasn't fear, at least Catra always said that it wasn't fear. She couldn't help but notice that Adora was always respectful of her and her hatred of water, even if the water wasn't deep.
A wave crashed into them, splashing them both. Adora sputtered as it drew back into the sea. Catra's ears and tail drooped. Her fur was completely soaked.

Great.

Out of the corner of her eye, she noticed Adora's fishing pole getting pulled out to the ocean.

Shit.

Catra reached out, her arm outstretched to grab it. Her hand slipped. Her arm buckled under her. She fell.

"Oof!"

She wasn't sure if that sound came from her or Adora. The fishing pole was getting further away.

Damn it.

Fuck!

"Catra, what–?"

She leapt forward, off of Adora. She splashed into the water. Cold. Stinging water. She closed her eyes, shielding them from the harshness of the salt and blindly reached out, her splayed out fingers anticipating the fishing rod. She knew where it *should* be. She felt it. She snatched it. She dragged it out of the coast's strong, watery grip. She pulled it towards her, for some reason, she fell backwards onto her back into the water, waves crashing over her as she did.

"Catra?! Are you okay?"

She heard splashing. The water pulled back and then crashed back down on her. Someone (probably Adora. It *had* to be Adora), plucked her out of the ocean. She lifted Catra up, and helped her to her feet. No one could say she never did anything for Adora. She had just faced her greatest ~~fear~~ enemy.

Yeah…

Enemy was the right word. It wasn't a fear after all. She wasn't *afraid* of water. She just didn't like water. Water was basically just an enemy; when it wasn't in a drinkable glass that is.

"Catra, what are– What *were* you doing?!"

“Saving your stupid fishing pole!” Catra retorted. What did it look like she was doing? “What do you think?!”

“You– You didn’t…” Adora’s brow furrowed. Her concern was evident in her eyes. “You didn’t need to…” Her words trailed off, her voice faltered.

Adora. The worried look on her face. The regret. She wouldn’t let Adora stew in her thoughts. Or in the feelings of worthlessness she was probably being consumed by now.

“I didn’t need to but I… I wanted to.” Catra decided on that answer. It was the truth; as simple as that.

“Catra…”

Catra thrusted the fishing pole into Adora’s hand and began to stalk out of the water, her back to Adora.. Whatever the blonde was going to say, died on her lips. Catra grabbed her tail as she reached the beach. She tried to ring the water out, as much as she could. When she was satisfied (or as satisfied as she could be), she released her tail. Damp but not soaking now. Her tail flickered and twitched for a bit as she made her way back to the towel fort. At least the sand didn’t feel as scorching hot as it had earlier.

There was a lot of splashing in the distance, followed by: “Catra! Catra! Hey, are you–”

“What, Adora?!” She spun around. She was fed up. She was tired. She was hungry. She was frustrated beyond measure. She was finally back in her towel fort, the one Adora had built for her.

Adora was just a few feet away from her. How had she moved that fast? Had she sprinted from the water to the towel fort?

“Are you okay?” Adora sounded uncertain. Scared?

Catra sighed.

"Yes, I'm okay."

Relief washed over Adora's features. Catra could see some of her stress fall off. *Some*. Maybe she needed to take charge. Adora was stressed. The whole point of today was combat stress. Well, a day at the beach fishing wasn't the way she could do it.

"Adora, can we *please* go home? Can we just…" Catra took a deep breath. She hoped Adora would listen. She wished that Adora would listen for her own sake. She wanted Adora to actually relax (and not do a supposedly relaxing hobby the internet suggested) for herself. If Adora wouldn't do it for herself, then maybe Catra could trick her.

She stepped out of the towel fort and stepped closer to Adora. Her tail brushed up against the blonde.

"Can we just go home, order some food, and chill on the couch for a bit?"

Adora seemed hesitant. The fishing rod was still in her hand. Alright, just in case… Catra changed tactics a little.

"You kind of owe me for saving your fishing pole," Catra said, matter-of-factly.

If she hadn't been watching Adora so closely, she might have missed the small smile that flashed across the blonde's face. Maybe that last point gave Adora an out. She wasn't giving up if she had to repay Catra for saving the fishing rod, right?

"Alright," Adora replied. She looked relieved.

Catra stepped closer. She slid an arm around Adora. She tucked herself under Adora's chin. A purr erupted as Adora wrapped her arms around her.

End Notes

Thank you so much for reading! Any kudos and/or comments are always appreciated and loved!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!